

MAN UP (TO HEALING)

A Mental Health Journal
for Men

Strength is not silence.
Real men feel. Real men heal.

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If you are in crisis: Call 988 | Crisis Text: Text HELLO to 741741

BREAKING THE STIGMA

Men die by suicide at 4x the rate of women. Not because men are weaker - but because men are taught to never ask for help.

Messages men receive:

- 'Man up' / 'Boys don't cry'
- 'Don't be so sensitive'
- 'Provide, protect, be strong - always'
- 'Handle it yourself'
- 'Therapy is for weak people'
- 'Just push through it'

THE TRUTH:

- **Feeling emotions IS strength**
- **Asking for help IS brave**
- **Vulnerability IS masculine**
- **You cannot pour from an empty cup**

EMOTIONS ARE NOT WEAKNESS

Most men grow up with only 2 'acceptable' emotions: happy and angry.

But under anger, there's almost always something else:

- Fear
- Hurt
- Shame
- Loneliness
- Grief
- Feeling disrespected
- Feeling powerless
- Sadness
- Overwhelm
- Exhaustion

Today, under my anger/frustration, I might actually feel:

EXPANDED EMOTION VOCABULARY

Beyond 'fine' and 'angry' - circle what fits today:

SAD:

lonely, hopeless, disappointed, grieving, empty, depressed, lost

ANGRY:

frustrated, disrespected, betrayed, bitter, resentful, annoyed

SCARED:

anxious, worried, insecure, vulnerable, panicked, uncertain

ASHAMED:

embarrassed, worthless, guilty, inadequate, exposed, failing

HAPPY:

content, proud, grateful, relieved, connected, hopeful, peaceful

TIRED:

burned out, depleted, numb, overwhelmed, defeated, checked out

THE ANGER ICEBERG

What people SEE: Anger, irritability, shutting down, aggression

What's UNDERNEATH (the real feelings):

Think about the last time you were really angry. Underneath was:

I felt: _____

I needed: _____

I was afraid of: _____

What would have actually helped: _____

My anger pattern:

Trigger: _____ -> Underlying feeling: _____

-> What I actually need: _____

STRESS MANAGEMENT FOR MEN

Healthy outlets (that actually work):

- Exercise (lifting, running, martial arts, sports)
- Time in nature (fishing, hiking, camping)
- Creative work (woodworking, music, cooking, writing)
- Connection (calling a friend, being honest with someone)
- Rest (actual rest, not just numbing with screens/alcohol)
- Routine (sleep, nutrition, movement - the basics matter)

What I'm currently doing to cope (be honest):

Is it helping or hurting long-term?

COMMUNICATION WITH PARTNER

Common patterns men fall into:

- Stonewalling (shutting down during conflict)
- Fixing instead of listening
- Minimizing partner's feelings
- Withdrawing when overwhelmed
- Expressing frustration as anger

Scripts to try:

'I need a minute to think before I respond.'

'I'm feeling [emotion] but I don't know how to express it yet.'

'I hear you. Tell me more about how that felt for you.'

'I'm struggling right now. Can you just be with me?'

'I'm sorry. I was wrong about that.'

FATHERHOOD STRUGGLES VALIDATION

Things no one tells dads:

- You might not bond immediately - that's normal
- You can love your kids AND miss your old life
- Postpartum depression affects dads too (10%)
- Feeling like a provider isn't enough is common
- Your own father wounds show up when you become a dad
- It's okay to not know what you're doing
- Needing time alone doesn't make you selfish

What I wish I could tell someone about being a dad:

WORK-LIFE BOUNDARIES

Your worth is not your productivity.

Current work hours per week (honestly): ____

Ideal work hours: ____

What I sacrifice for work: _____

One boundary I could set this week: _____

Signs of burnout:

- ☐ Dreading every morning
- ☐ Physical exhaustion that rest doesn't fix
- ☐ Cynicism about everything
- ☐ Feeling like nothing matters
- ☐ Using substances to cope with work stress

SUBSTANCE USE SELF-CHECK

Honest assessment (no judgment, just awareness):

- ☐ Do I drink/use more than I intend to?
- ☐ Do I need it to relax or sleep?
- ☐ Would I feel anxious without it?
- ☐ Has someone expressed concern?
- ☐ Do I hide how much I use?
- ☐ Is it causing problems at work/home?
- ☐ Am I using it to avoid feelings?

If you checked 2+, consider talking to someone.

SAMHSA Helpline: 1-800-662-4357 (free, confidential)

FRIENDSHIP AND ISOLATION

Men lose friends as they age. This is an epidemic.

My close friends (who I can really talk to): ____

Last time I hung out with a friend: _____

Last time I told a friend how I'm really doing: _____

Ways to build connection:

- Join a league/club/group (sports, hobby, church)
- Be the one to reach out first
- Say yes to one invitation this week
- Start a regular thing (weekly basketball, monthly dinner)
- Be vulnerable with ONE person about how you're really doing

PHYSICAL + MENTAL HEALTH CONNECTION

Your body and mind are the same system:

Current sleep (hours/quality): _____

Exercise this week: _____

Nutrition (honest): _____

Water intake: _____

Substances used: _____

Screen time: _____

ONE physical change I'll make this week:

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 1

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 2

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 3

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 4

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 5

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 6

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 7

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 8

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 9

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 10

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 11

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 12

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 13

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 14

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

DAILY CHECK-IN - Day 15

Date: _____

Mood (1-10): ____ Energy (1-10): ____ Sleep (hours): ____

One honest thought (what's really on my mind):

One thing I need right now:

One win today (any size):

Did I connect with someone? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I move my body? ☐ Yes ☐ No

WHEN TO GET PROFESSIONAL HELP

Consider therapy or counseling if:

- You're thinking about not being alive
- Anger is damaging relationships
- Substances are the only way you cope
- You feel nothing (numbness for weeks)
- Sleep is consistently terrible
- You're isolating from everyone
- Work performance is declining
- Physical symptoms with no medical cause

Resources:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988

Veterans Crisis Line: 988, then press 1

SAMHSA: 1-800-662-4357

Therapy for Black Men: therapyforblackmen.org

Man Therapy: mantherapy.org

MY PERSONAL COMMITMENT TO HEALING

I commit to:

- ☐ Being honest with myself about how I'm doing
- ☐ Asking for help when I need it
- ☐ Not numbing my pain with _____
- ☐ Connecting with at least one person per week
- ☐ Moving my body regularly
- ☐ Being patient with my own healing
- ☐ Remembering that vulnerability is strength

Signed: _____ Date: _____

You are not broken. You are a man who feels deeply.

That is not weakness. That is being fully human.